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Social Text, No. 15. (Autumn, 1986), pp. 140-144.

Stable URL:
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Tue Jul 10 01:00:41 2007

Forgetting Baudrillard*

SYLVERE LOTRINGER/JEAN BAUDRILLARD

Sylvere Lotringer: For Nieztsche, the philosopher must decipher action. He must actively evaluate the forces confronting each other in society. You, on the other hand, proclaim the "end of the social."[1] *You hypostasize a complex reality in an abstraction, only to send the abstraction immediately back to unreality. But if you conceive of the social as the depletion of an empty form, what role, then, is left for theory?*

Jean Baudrillard: If the social ever existed, it's not as a representation of society, nor in any positive sense; rather as a challenge to the reality of things, as a virulent myth. This is how Georges Bataille saw sociology: as a challenge to the very nature of the social and to society.

But if the social has become weightless, what does myth attack? And for what cause?

I admit that question of theory bothers me. Where is theory today? Is it completely satellized? Is theory wandering in realms which no longer have anything to do with real facts? What is analysis?

As long as you consider that there is such a thing as a real world, theory has a place, let's say a dialectical position, for the sake of argument. Then theory and reality can be exchanged at some point—and that's ideality. In that case, there still is a point of contact between the two: you can transform the world, and theory does transform the world . . .

That's not at all my position any more. Moreover, it never was. But I have never succeeded in formulating it. In my opinion, theory is simply a challenge to the real; a challenge to the world to exist; often, furthermore, a challenge to God to exist. Religion, in the beginning, in its heretical phase, was always a negation—at times a violent one—of the real world, and this is what gave it strength. Later on, religion became a process of reconciliation rather than a pleasure or reality principle. Well, this can hold true for theory as well: a theory can attempt to reconcile the real with theory itself. And then there is a principle of antagonism, an absolutely irreconciliable, almost Manichean antagonism. You maintain a position of challenge, which is different from unreality.

* Part of a series of interviews (1984-86) to be published in the *Semiotext(e)* Foreign Agent Series.

Still, isn't that exactly what you do: make any stake unreal by pushing it to the limit?

But I hold no position on reality. The real doesn't exist. It is the insurmountable limit of theory. The real is not an objective status of things, it is the point at which theory can do nothing.

That doesn't necessarily make of theory a failure. The real is actually a challenge to the theoretical edifice. At that point, however, theory is no longer theory, it is the event itself. There is no reality with respect to which theory could become dissident, or heretical. Rather, it is the objectivity of things we must question. What is this objectivity? In the so-called "real world," don't things always happen by a divergence, a trajectory, a curve, which is in no way the linear curve of evolution? Perhaps we should develop a model of drifting plates, to speak in seismic terms, in the theory of catastrophes. The seismic is our form, it is the slipping and sliding of the referential, the end of the infrastructure. There is nothing left but shifting movements that provoke very powerful, raw events. Events can no longer be seen as revolutions, or effects of the superstructure, but as underground effects of skidding, fractal zones in which things happen. Between the plates, continents do not quite fit together, they slip under and over each other. There is no more system of reference to tell us what happened to the geography of things. We can only take a geoseismic view. Perhaps this is also true in the construction of a society, a mentality, a value-system. Things no longer meet head-on, they slip past one another.

Everyone claims to "be in the real." But the test of reality is not decisive. Nothing happens in the real.

So for you theory has become its own and only reality.

At a certain point I felt—assuming that the real and social practices are indeed there—that I was launched on a trajectory that was increasingly diverging, becoming asymptotic. It would have been an error to keep trying to catch hold of that zig-zagging line of reality; you had to let it run all the way to the end. Then any objection about the relation to reality falls on the side; we are in a completely arbitrary situation, but it has an undeniable internal necessity.

I wonder if there isn't a kind of "skidding" endemic to theory itself. When theory, following its own logic, manages to round itself up, then it disappears. Its accomplishment is its abolition.

Yes, I really believe that's true. Can theory (I'm speaking here of what I've done)

produce, not a model, but a utopian, metaphorical representation of an event, even as its entire cyclical trajectory is being completed? I believe there is a destiny of theory, a curve we can't escape. You know that I always make ideas appear,but then I hasten to make them disappear. That's what the game has always consisted of. Strictly speaking, nothing remains but a sense of dizziness. If this game didn't exist, there would be no pleasure in writing, or in theorizing.

Theory as the pleasure of disappearing . . . Isn't that a little bit suicidal?

It's suicidal, but in a good way. There is an art of disappearing, a way of modulating it and making it into a state of grace. That's what I'm trying to master in theory.

Theory implodes.

If only theory could implode, absorb its own meaning, then it would master its own disappearance. Actually, we have to keep chocking back the meanings we produce. It's not so easy to create a void, to constitute a concentric knot of implosion. And, besides, there's catastrophe all around it. Can we implode in the real without going all the way to suicide? In our relation to others, we continually play on the process of disappearance, not by making ourselves scarce, but by challenging the other to make us reappear. That's what "seduction" is about: not a process of expansion and conquest, but the implosive process of the game.

You actually theorize the way gamblers go to the casino. You seem to derive wicked pleasure from playing with concepts without yourself feeling the slightest bit implicated in the effects you let loose. You swoop down on a theoretical object–Foucault, for example[2]–with a cold passion, and you totally disconnect it from its own thrust . . .

There has to be some pleasure at stake, of course, which is neither the pleasure of prophecy nor, I think, of annihilation (destruction for destruction's sake). A perverse pleasure, in short. Theory indeed must be played like a game of chance.

The secret of gambling, we agreed, is that money doesn't exist. Is that also the secret of theory in relation to truth?

The secret of theory is, indeed, that truth doesn't exist. You can't confront truth in any way, only play with some kind of provocative logic. Truth constitutes a space that can no longer be occupied. The whole stratgy is not to occupy it but to work around it so that others get caught in it.

If theory can no longer occupy anything, can it at least anticipate or hasten the catastrophic aspect of things?

Things are always ahead of us, as Rilke said, therefore they are always unpredictable. We can't escape it anyway since discourse is in the domain of metaphor. We are condemned to using ambiguous extrapolations. When we claim a truth, we're simply pushing effects of meaning to the extreme within a given model.

You've cut yourself off from every system of reference, but not from referentiality. I don't believe that what you're describing is a challenge to the real—it is a challenge internal to theory. *You don't criticize the genealogical attitude (Foucault), or the libidinal position (Gilles Deleuze, Felix Guattari), you send them spinning away like tops. You wholly embrace the movement that animates them, you amplify their concepts to the maximum, pulling them into the vortex of your own dizziness. You draw them into an endless spiral which, like the treatment of myths by Levi-Strauss, leads them bit by bit to their own exhaustion.*

That's right. Theory is exterminated. It no longer has any *term.* That's one mode of disappearance.

By pushing theory to its limit the way you do, you're hyper-realizing it. You take away from theory any substance it might have, and then you "forget it" as a body in suspension might be left behind. You don't even simulate the real, you play God's advocate, the evil genius of theory. More Foucaultian than Foucault, you evaporate his microphysics; more schizo than Deleuze and Guattari, you straddle their fluxes, denying them any resting point. You are not the metaphysician you would like people to take you for—you are a meta-theoretician. *A "simulator" of theory. No wonder theoreticians accuse you of being an agent provocateur. You aren't theoretical, you are worse. You modulate theory and make it undecided. You put it in a state of grace into which you dare the world to follow you.*

Theory itself is a simulation. At least, that's how I use it. Both simulation and challenge.

You catch concepts in their own trap—that is, in yours—abolishing every certainty by dint of fidelity. That's the position of "humor," which Deleuze has theorized. You don't theorize humor though, you humorize theory. You adopt the imperceptible insolence of the servant challenging his master (his intellectual masters) to take him seriously.

Calling your bluff would mean getting entangled in your game, but to evade

your challenge amounts to lending you a hand. You "forget" those whom you vampirize, but you never allow yourself to be forgotten. You are just like the media in this respect. What allows you to understand it so well, is that you're included in it. You both play the same game, both use the same strategy. You don't speak about the media, the media speaks through you. As soon as you turn on your theoretical screen, the great myths of history turn into a soap opera—or into serials, as Levi-Strauss would say. You make them share the fate of the TV "Holocaust" that you analyzed so well.[3]

I don't deny history. It's an immense toy.

Yes, if you remain glued to the screen, sucked up by the image, or fascinated by the giddiness of commutations.

Our anti-destiny is the media universe. I don't see how to make this mental leap which would make it possible to reach the fractal or fatal zones where things would really be happening. Collectively, we are behind the radio-active screen of information. It is no more possible to go behind that curtain than it is to leap over your own shadow.

You are one of the few thinkers to confront the gorgon of the media from within, at the risk of being paralyzed. Yet, you, too, need an adversary in order to succumb to your own fascination. That partner can't be the media, since you are yourself behind the screen; nor can it be reality, which you have left far behind. That partner is theory. Cultivating paradox in order to revulse theory, to upset its vision, to bring it to a crisis by playing and displaying the card of its own seriousness–that, I believe, is your pleasure, the only one maybe, or the only one socializable . . .

I admit that I greatly enjoy provoking that revulsion. But right away people ask, "What can you do with that?" It relies after all on an extraordinary *deception.* There is nothing to be had from it.

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1. "The End of the Social" is the second part in *In the Shadow of the Silent Majorities* (New York: Semiotext(e) Foreign Agents Series, 1983).

2. *Forget Foucault,* (New York: Semiotext(e) Foreign Agents Series, 1986).

3. *Simulacres et Simulation* (Paris: Galilee, 1981).